> At Mandu, a deserter presented himself. The officers wanted to torture him to make him reveal where the enemy had hidden its treasure. Humayun replied: ‘Since this man has come to me of his own free will, it would not be magnanimous to use force against him. If success can be achieved by means of kindness, why use harsh measures? Order a banquet to be prepared. Ply the man with wine, and then ask him where the treasure is hidden.’

Unfortunately, Humayun himself partook too readily of the pleasures he proposed to the prisoner, often disappearing after a hard-won battle for many weeks into his harem, where he ‘unfurled the carpet of pleasure’ and gave himself over to opium and wine. His father would have been entirely unimpressed by this behaviour—something he had witnessed in his own uncles in Herat, and blamed on an increasingly sedentary lifestyle. ‘They were good at conversation, arranging parties and in social manners,’ wrote Babur about these pleasure-loving uncles, ‘but they were strangers to soldiering, strategy, equipment, bold fight and military encounter.’

In the darkest moment of his life, Humayun had a dream on the banks of the Ravi which must have offered consolation to the mystically minded Padshah, for he dreamed of a son. ‘His blessed heart was cast down’, Gulbadan, Humayun’s sister, admitted in her family chronicle, and when he fell asleep, he ‘saw in a dream a venerable man, dressed in green from head to foot and carrying a staff ’. This ancient man identified himself as ‘Ahmad of Jam’, the twelfth-century mystic who was so exceptionally large that he was known as Zinda-Fil, or Colossal Elephant, and he promised Humayun an illustrious son for whom he proposed the name Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar.

It was not only Humayun who experienced miraculous premonitions and extraordinary occurrences around Akbar’s birth. Shamsuddin Ataka[*] Khan, his future wakil,[†] had a dream when he was only twenty-two in which ‘he saw the moon come into his arms’, a sign which was joyfully interpreted as an intimation of great good fortune to come. Akbar’s mother, too, when she was pregnant with him, was said to glow with an effulgence so bright from her forehead that her brother, Khwaja Muazzam, said that ‘the divine light so streamed from the shining brows that he had not strength to gaze steadily at it’. And Jiji Anaga, his future milk mother, had a vision, in which she said ‘a great light approached me and entered my